

COMPLETE CHESS LEARNING LIBRARY

Attacking Chess and King Safety

Build attacks from development, lines, defenders, and central control

COURSE BOOK

20 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

How to Use This Course

ONE CHAPTER, FOUR PASSES

1. Read the position without moving pieces. 2. State your plan and the opponent's counterplay. 3. Study the decision rules. 4. Close the book and reconstruct the position from memory.

RETRIEVAL SCHEDULE

Review the chapter the next day, one week later, and after a game that reaches a similar structure. Retrieval is more valuable than rereading.

BOARD ROUTINE

Opponent's threat - forcing moves - loose pieces - worst piece - central break - best reply - choose and stop.

The course book explains each model position. The separate workbook forces recall, prediction, and self-scoring. Use the book first, then attempt the matching workbook page without looking back.

Engine evaluations are intentionally not the lesson. The aim is to store human decision rules that remain useful when the exact move order changes.

Course Map

MODULE	CHAPTERS
ATTACKING CHESS AND KING SAFETY	20

01. Loose Pieces Tell The Truth



ATTACKING CHESS AND KING SAFETY

READ THE POSITION

Identify what is loose, then ask which forcing move can exploit it.

PRIMARY PLAN

UNDEFENDED: Mark every piece defended zero times.; OVERLOADED: Find defenders tied to two duties.; ALIGNED: Trace kings, queens, and rooks on lines.; FORCING: Test checks, captures, and direct threats.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'I cannot see a tactic' with 'First inventory tactical targets.'; Replace 'It is defended' with 'Ask whether the defender can move.'; Replace 'Only checks matter' with 'Use captures and double attacks too.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. d3 Nf6 5. O-O O-O 6. c3 d6 7. Re1

MEMORY RULE

Before hunting a tactic, find the pieces asking to be attacked.

01. Decision Framework

Loose Pieces Tell The Truth

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	INVENTORY: Find loose pieces for both sides.; COMPARE: Notice who has the weaker target.; GENERATE: Create forcing candidate moves.; CALCULATE: Follow the most forcing reply.; CLEANUP: Check what remains loose afterward.
PIECE JOB	UNDEFENDED: A piece with no defender is a standing invitation.; OVERLOADED: One defender may be doing two incompatible jobs.; ALIGNED: Pieces on one line invite pins, skewers, and discoveries.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	TARGETS: Combinations need something to attack.; DEFENDERS: Count their duties, not merely their number.; LINES: Geometry creates tactical possibilities.; BOTH SIDES: Your loose piece may refute your idea.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

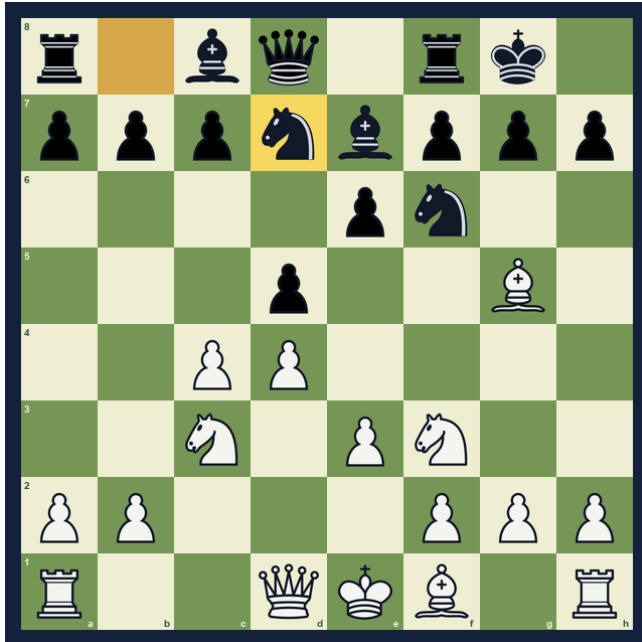
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Before hunting a tactic, find the pieces asking to be attacked.

02. Compare The Two Kings



ATTACKING CHESS AND KING SAFETY

READ THE POSITION

Compare access, defenders, and attacking pieces before opening lines.

PRIMARY PLAN

ACCESS: Count useful checking routes.; DEFENDERS: Count effective nearby defenders.; FORCES: Count attackers that can join quickly.; COST: Name what opening the position concedes.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Their king looks open' with 'Ask whether your pieces can reach it.'; Replace 'My king is castled' with 'Check lines and missing defenders.'; Replace 'I should sacrifice' with 'Count arriving forces before material.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Be7 5. Bg5 O-O 6. e3 Nbd7

MEMORY RULE

Do not attack a picture; attack a king your pieces can reach.

02. Decision Framework

Compare The Two Kings

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	COMPARE: Inspect both kings, not only theirs.; ACCESS: Find checks that can actually arrive.; RECRUIT: Count pieces within two moves.; OPEN: Choose the safest useful line break.; RECHECK: Confirm your king survives the race.
PIECE JOB	ACCESS: Can checks reach the king without losing time?; DEFENDERS: Are nearby pieces able to protect critical squares?; FORCES: How many attackers can join before the position changes?
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	RELATIVE: King safety is always a comparison.; ACCESS: An exposed king may still be unreachable.; NUMBERS: Attack with more pieces than the defense.; COST: Opening lines works in both directions.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Do not attack a picture; attack a king your pieces can reach.

03. Count Attackers And Defenders



ATTACKING CHESS AND KING SAFETY

READ THE POSITION

Include hidden defenders, pinned pieces, and the value of the final occupant.

PRIMARY PLAN

NUMBER: Count legal attackers and defenders.; QUALITY: Remove pinned or immobile defenders.; ORDER: Start exchanges with the least valuable piece.; RESULT: Picture the final piece on the square.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'It is defended twice' with 'Check whether both defenders can move.'; Replace 'I win the first capture' with 'Follow the entire exchange sequence.'; Replace 'The numbers are equal' with 'Compare the value and order too.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 dxc4 5. a4 Bf5 6. e3 e6 7. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

When a square is crowded, replace intuition with an inventory.

03. Decision Framework

Count Attackers And Defenders

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	MARK: Identify the contested square.; COUNT: List legal attackers and defenders.; FILTER: Remove pieces that are pinned.; ORDER: Run captures from lowest value upward.; RESULT: Evaluate the final material and position.
PIECE JOB	NUMBER: Start with how many legal captures each side has.; QUALITY: Pinned or overloaded defenders may not truly defend.; ORDER: The cheapest attacker often determines the exchange sequence.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	LEGAL: A pinned piece may not be a defender.; ORDER: Capture sequence changes the arithmetic.; FINAL: Evaluate the last position, not the first trade.; POSITION: Material gain can still lose activity or king safety.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

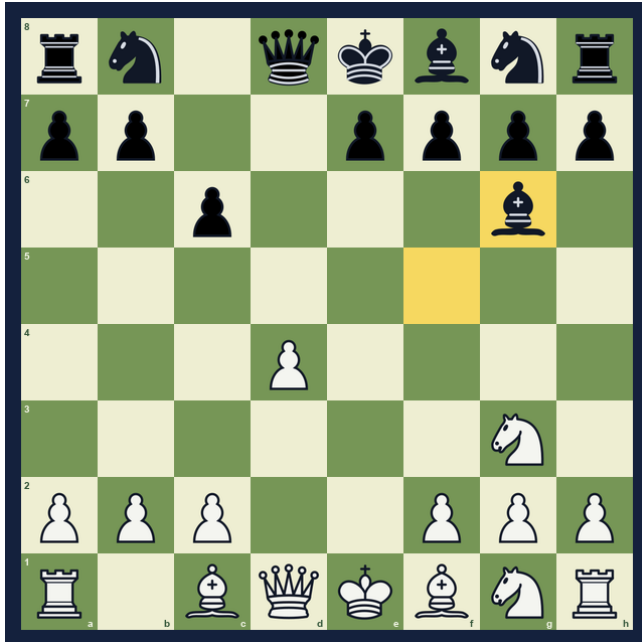
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: When a square is crowded, replace intuition with an inventory.

04. What Is The Opponent'S Idea?



ATTACKING CHESS AND KING SAFETY

READ THE POSITION

Find the opponent's strongest useful continuation, then decide whether it must be stopped.

PRIMARY PLAN

THREAT: What happens if I make a waiting move?;

IMPROVE: Which of their pieces wants a better square?;

URGENCY: Can the idea wait one move?; RESPONSE: Can my move answer it while improving?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'They attacked something' with 'Ask what happens if you ignore it.'; Replace 'I must stop their idea' with 'Judge whether it is actually urgent.'; Replace 'Defense means retreat' with 'Prefer a useful move with two purposes.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 dxe4 4. Nxe4 Bf5 5. Ng3 Bg6

MEMORY RULE

See their idea clearly, then respond by choice rather than fear.

04. Decision Framework

What Is The Opponent'S Idea?

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	WAIT: Imagine passing your turn.; PREDICT: Name their strongest next move.; VALUE: Judge what that move would gain.; DECIDE: Stop, delay, or ignore it.; MULTIPURPOSE: Choose a response that also improves.
PIECE JOB	THREAT: A real threat changes material, king safety, or structure.; IMPROVEMENT: A quiet move may activate their worst piece.; URGENCY: Some ideas can be met after you improve your own position.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	PREDICT: Name one serious opponent idea.; TEST: Use a waiting move to expose urgency.; SELECT: Not every idea deserves prevention.; IMPROVE: The best defense often serves your plan too.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: See their idea clearly, then respond by choice rather than fear.

05. Improve Before You Attack



ATTACKING CHESS AND KING SAFETY

READ THE POSITION

Bring the least active useful piece into play before forcing the position open.

PRIMARY PLAN

PARTICIPANTS: Count active attacking pieces.; RESTRICT: Remove or limit key defenders.; BREAK: Identify the line-opening move.; COUNTERPLAY: Check what the opponent gets in return.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'A threat means an attack' with 'Count how many pieces can follow.'; Replace 'Open lines immediately' with 'Place pieces before changing the structure.'; Replace 'Sacrifice to keep momentum' with 'Improve the last attacker first.'

REFERENCE LINE 1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nd2 c5 4. exd5 exd5 5. Ngf3 Nc6

MEMORY RULE

The strongest attacking move is often the move that invites one more piece.

05. Decision Framework

Improve Before You Attack

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	COUNT: Name every possible participant.; IMPROVE: Recruit the worst useful piece.; RESTRICT: Challenge the best defender.; PREPARE: Support the intended pawn break.; OPEN: Strike when the pieces are ready.
PIECE JOB	PARTICIPATION: Count pieces that can reach the target quickly.; RESTRICTION: Limit defensive pieces before sacrificing material or structure.; BREAK: Open lines only after your pieces occupy them.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	NUMBERS: A real attack needs enough participants.; ORDER: Place pieces before opening lines.; DEFENDERS: Restriction can be stronger than a threat.; PATIENCE: One quiet move may make the attack unavoidable.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The strongest attacking move is often the move that invites one more piece.

06. Build A Real Outpost



ATTACKING CHESS AND KING SAFETY

READ THE POSITION

Use a square that cannot be chased and from which the piece influences something important.

PRIMARY PLAN

STABLE: Can an enemy pawn challenge the square?;

SUPPORTED: Can the piece remain there safely?;

INFLUENCE: What useful squares or targets does it affect?;

ROUTE: Can the piece reach it without losing time?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'It is a central square' with 'Prove the piece cannot be chased.'; Replace 'A knight belongs there' with 'Ask what the knight does from there.'; Replace 'Occupy it immediately' with 'Prepare support and a safe route.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. Nf3 Nf6 3. Bf4 e6 4. e3 Bd6 5. Bg3 O-O 6. Bd3

MEMORY RULE

A strong square is valuable only when a strong piece can use it.

06. Decision Framework

Build A Real Outpost

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	MARK: Find squares enemy pawns cannot control.; VALUE: Choose one with real influence.; SUPPORT: Secure it with a pawn or piece.; ROUTE: Find the safest path inward.; OCCUPY: Enter when exchanges favor you.
PIECE JOB	STABILITY: Enemy pawns cannot drive the piece away.; SUPPORT: Your pawn or piece can maintain the occupant.; INFLUENCE: The square attacks targets or restricts important play.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	STABLE: A true outpost cannot be chased by pawns.; USEFUL: The occupant must affect the game.; SUPPORTED: Do not turn the outpost into a trap.; ROUTE: Preparation is part of occupation.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A strong square is valuable only when a strong piece can use it.

07. Use A Space Advantage



ATTACKING CHESS AND KING SAFETY

READ THE POSITION

Use extra territory to improve pieces and restrict breaks before forcing action.

PRIMARY PLAN

ROOM: Which piece gains the best maneuvering route?; RESTRICT: Which enemy piece has no square?; BREAKS: What freeing pawn move do they need?; PROTECT: Which advanced pawn could become weak?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Space means attack now' with 'Improve pieces while they remain cramped.'; Replace 'Push another pawn' with 'Protect the territory already gained.'; Replace 'Trade pieces freely' with 'Keep pieces when the opponent lacks space.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. d3 d6 7. c3 O-O

MEMORY RULE

Use space to improve quietly until the opponent runs out of useful moves.

07. Decision Framework

Use A Space Advantage

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	IDENTIFY: Find the cramped enemy piece.; PREVENT: Control their freeing pawn break.; MANEUVER: Improve your least useful piece.; PROTECT: Reinforce advanced pawns.; OPEN: Break through only when ready.
PIECE JOB	ROOM: Your pieces can switch squares without blocking one another.; RESTRICTION: Enemy pieces have fewer useful destinations.; RISK: Advanced pawns can become targets if support disappears.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	ROOM: Space is useful maneuvering capacity.; KEEP PIECES: Crowding hurts the side with less space.; BREAKS: Stop the move that would free them.; CONTROL: Do not let advanced pawns become targets.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Use space to improve quietly until the opponent runs out of useful moves.

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Support the break, occupy the lines it will open, and calculate the opponent's best reaction.

SUPPORT: Is the breaking pawn adequately supported?
 PLACEMENT: Which pieces improve after lines open?
 RESPONSES: Test capture, advance, and refusal.; OUTCOME:
 Which structure remains after each reply?

Replace 'The break is thematic' with 'Check whether the pieces are ready now.'; Replace 'They must capture' with 'Calculate advance and refusal too.'; Replace 'Open position is good' with 'Name which pieces actually improve.'

MEMORY RULE

The best pawn break is prepared before it becomes urgent.

08. Decision Framework

Prepare The Pawn Break

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	NAME: Identify the structural break.; PLACE: Move pieces onto future lines.; SUPPORT: Reinforce the advancing pawn.; TEST: Calculate all three responses.; BREAK: Play it when every reply helps.
PIECE JOB	SUPPORT: The advancing pawn needs enough protection or tactical justification.; PLACEMENT: Rooks and bishops should face the lines that will open.; RESPONSE: The opponent may capture, advance, or ignore the break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	PERMANENT: Pawn breaks cannot be taken back.; PREPARE: Place pieces before opening lines.; RESPONSES: Capture is only one possible reply.; RESULT: Evaluate the resulting structure, not the push.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

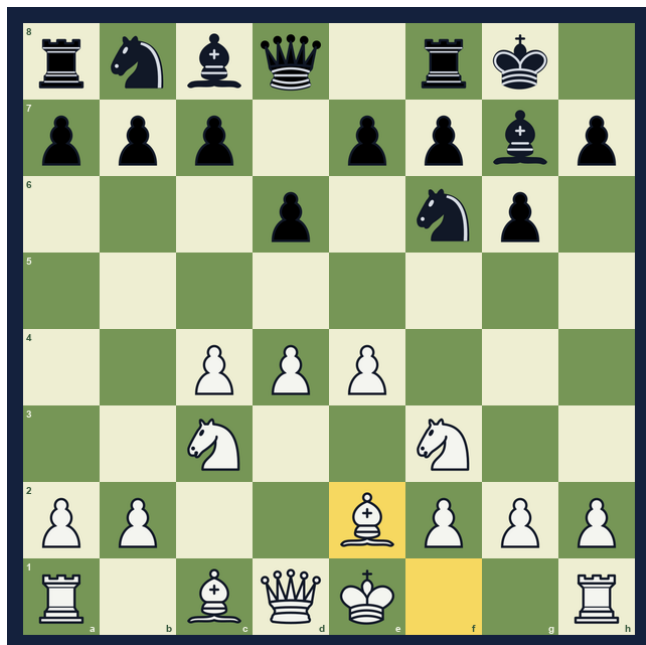
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The best pawn break is prepared before it becomes urgent.

09. Stop Counterplay Without Passivity



ATTACKING CHESS AND KING SAFETY

READ THE POSITION

Identify the freeing break, invasion square, or active piece that gives the opponent play.

PRIMARY PLAN

SOURCE: What creates their active play?; CONTROL: Can one move block or discourage it?; PROGRESS: Does the move improve your own position?; RELEASE: What happens if they achieve the break?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Stop every threat' with 'Find the one source of activity.'; Replace 'Defend with retreat' with 'Use control, trades, or a useful blockade.'; Replace 'Keep attacking' with 'Spend one move removing their best resource.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2

MEMORY RULE

Good prevention does not stop your game; it clears the road for it.

09. Decision Framework

Stop Counterplay Without Passivity

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	PREDICT: Name their best active idea.; TRACE: Find the break or square it needs.; BLOCK: Choose the smallest effective restraint.; IMPROVE: Make the move serve your plan too.; CONTINUE: Return to conversion after control.
PIECE JOB	SOURCE: Counterplay usually depends on one break, file, or piece.; CONTROL: A single square can sometimes stop the entire idea.; PROGRESS: Your restraining move should preserve a path forward.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	ONE SOURCE: Counterplay is often structurally narrow.; MINIMUM: Use the least passive effective move.; DUAL PURPOSE: Restriction should also improve.; RETURN: Once controlled, continue your own plan.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

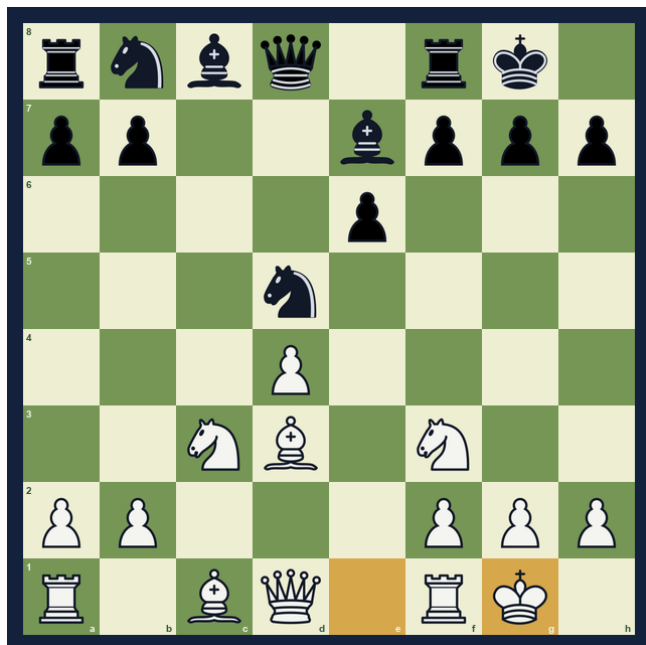
ACTIVE RECALL

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3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Good prevention does not stop your game; it clears the road for it.

10. Control A Color Complex



ATTACKING CHESS AND KING SAFETY

READ THE POSITION

Enter through one square, then transfer to another faster than the defense can respond.

PRIMARY PLAN

PAWNS: Which color can their pawns no longer cover?

BISHOP: Is the matching bishop absent or restricted?

ENTRY: Which weak square can you reach first?; ROUTE:

Where can the piece transfer next?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Attack one weak square' with 'Use it as an entry into a network.'; Replace 'Trade bishops automatically' with 'Check which colors become undefended.'; Replace 'Push a pawn to chase' with 'Notice the new squares the push abandons.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c6 2. d4 d5 3. exd5 cxd5 4. c4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e6 6. Nf3 Be7 7. cxd5 Nxd5 8. Bd3 O-O 9. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Do not merely occupy a weak square; use it to travel through the position.

10. Decision Framework

Control A Color Complex

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	MAP: Mark the weak squares of one color.; REMOVE: Exchange the natural defender if useful.; ENTER: Occupy the safest access square.; TRANSFER: Move between related targets.; FIX: Prevent pawns from repairing the complex.
PIECE JOB	PAWNS: Pawn moves permanently abandon squares of the opposite color.; BISHOP: Trading a bishop can remove the natural color defender.; ROUTES: Queens and knights can move through several related weak squares.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	NETWORK: Several weak squares support one another.; BISHOP: The missing color defender matters greatly.; ENTRY: One square can unlock the whole position.; PAWNS: Every pawn move gives up squares forever.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Do not merely occupy a weak square; use it to travel through the position.

11. Exchange The Best Defender



ATTACKING CHESS AND KING SAFETY

READ THE POSITION

Identify the piece whose removal changes the opponent's entire defensive geometry.

PRIMARY PLAN

CONTROL: Which piece guards the key square?; JOBS: Which defender performs several duties?; REPLACE: What piece or pawn recaptures?; CHANGE: What becomes possible after removal?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Trade the nearest defender' with 'Find the piece with the most duties.'; Replace 'Give up bishop for knight' with 'Name the squares gained afterward.'; Replace 'Exchange and then decide' with 'Calculate the replacement before trading.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. Nc3 Be7 5. Bg5 O-O 6. e3 Nbd7 7. Qc2 c5 8. cxd5 exd5 9. Bd3

MEMORY RULE

Remove the piece that holds the position together, then act before it is replaced.

11. Decision Framework

Exchange The Best Defender

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	TARGET: Name the square or king you want to reach.; TRACE: Find every meaningful defender.; RANK: Identify the defender with multiple jobs.; REMOVE: Choose a favorable exchange method.; ENTER: Use the newly available route immediately.
PIECE JOB	CONTROL: One piece may guard the critical entry square.; CONNECTION: A defender can link otherwise scattered pieces.; REPLACEMENT: The value of exchange depends on what replaces it.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	FUNCTION: Judge defenders by the jobs they perform.; OVERLOAD: Multiple duties reveal the key piece.; REPLACEMENT: Recapture may repair the defense.; TIMING: Exploit the removal before regrouping.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Remove the piece that holds the position together, then act before it is replaced.

12. Make Your Pieces Work Together



ATTACKING CHESS AND KING SAFETY

READ THE POSITION

Choose a target or break, then give each piece a compatible job.

PRIMARY PLAN

TARGET: What common objective matters?; JOBS: What role can each piece perform?; CONFLICT: Are pieces blocking or duplicating one another?; TIMING: Which piece must arrive first?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Every piece is active' with 'Check whether they share a target.'; Replace 'Double pieces anywhere' with 'Coordinate around an entry or break.'; Replace 'Move the closest piece' with 'Choose the correct order of arrival.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 Re8 9. Nge2 Nf8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Do not ask whether each piece is active; ask whether the pieces agree.

12. Decision Framework

Make Your Pieces Work Together

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	NAME: Choose one concrete objective.; ASSIGN: Give each piece a useful job.; UNBLOCK: Remove traffic between pieces.; ORDER: Bring the enabling piece first.; EXECUTE: Open the position when all can help.
PIECE JOB	TARGET: Pieces coordinate when they influence the same problem.; SUPPORT: One piece protects the route or square another needs.; TIMING: The pieces should arrive before the position changes.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	PURPOSE: Activity without a shared aim is scattered.; ROLES: Attackers, supporters, and restrainers all matter.; SPACE: Pieces need squares without blocking each other.; ORDER: Coordination depends on move sequence.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Do not ask whether each piece is active; ask whether the pieces agree.

13. Forcing Moves With Purpose



ATTACKING CHESS AND KING SAFETY

READ THE POSITION

Generate forcing moves, then reject the ones that improve the opponent's position.

PRIMARY PLAN

FORCE: How many sensible replies remain?; RESULT: Where does the king or recapturing piece land?; PURPOSE: What does the move actually gain?; EXIT: Can you continue if the attack ends?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Always check first' with 'Test whether the check improves their king.'; Replace 'Capture because it is forcing' with 'Evaluate the recapture and resulting activity.'; Replace 'Keep the initiative' with 'Know where the forcing sequence ends.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 c5 4. c3 Nc6 5. Nf3 Bd7 6. Be2 f6 7. O-O fxe5 8. dxe5 Qc7

MEMORY RULE

Use forcing moves to simplify the tree, then let evaluation choose the move.

13. Decision Framework

Forcing Moves With Purpose

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	LIST: Notice checks, captures, and direct threats.; FILTER: Remove moves with an obvious good reply.; FOLLOW: Calculate the opponent's most resistant answer.; STOP: Reach a stable position.; EVALUATE: Judge the result without excitement.
PIECE JOB	REPLIES: A forcing move reduces the opponent's reasonable choices.; RESULT: The final position still decides whether the move is good.; PURPOSE: Every check or capture should serve a tactical or positional aim.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	ATTENTION: Forcing moves deserve inspection, not obedience.; KING: A check may improve the king's location.; RECAPTURE: A capture can activate the opponent.; END: Know the position after the forcing moves stop.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

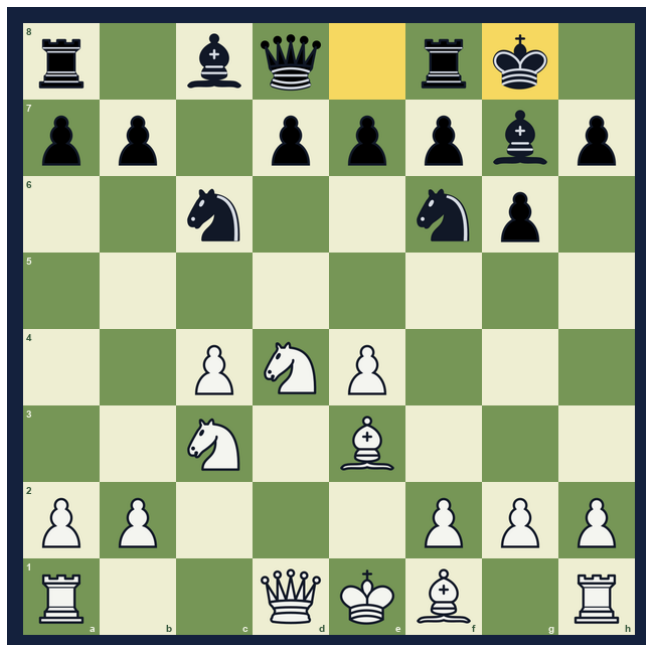
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Use forcing moves to simplify the tree, then let evaluation choose the move.

14. Calculate Until The Position Is Quiet



ATTACKING CHESS AND KING SAFETY

READ THE POSITION

Continue until checks, captures, and immediate threats no longer control the next move.

PRIMARY PLAN

FORCING: Does either side still have a forcing reply?; SAFETY: Are kings and major pieces stable?; EVALUATE: Who is better in the quiet position?; COMPARE: Apply the same stopping point to other lines.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'I saw three moves' with 'Continue if the position is still forcing.'; Replace 'I won material' with 'Check whether king safety or recapture changes it.'; Replace 'The line feels good' with 'Name the final stable evaluation.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 g6 5. c4 Bg7 6. Be3 Nf6 7. Nc3 O-O

MEMORY RULE

Do not stop because the line is long; stop because the position is stable.

14. Decision Framework

Calculate Until The Position Is Quiet

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	ENTER: Begin with the critical candidate.; FORCE: Follow the most demanding reply.; CLEAN: Resolve checks and captures.; STABILIZE: Reach a position with normal choices.; JUDGE: Evaluate material, safety, and activity.
PIECE JOB	FORCING: Unanswered forcing moves mean the line is unfinished.; STABILITY: Material, king safety, and loose pieces must be understandable.; EVALUATION: Only a quiet position can be compared reliably.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	DEPTH: Count stability, not a fixed number of moves.; UNFINISHED: Forcing replies mean calculation must continue.; QUIET: Stable positions can be evaluated honestly.; CONSISTENT: Compare candidates at equivalent endpoints.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Do not stop because the line is long; stop because the position is stable.

15. Recognize Tactical Triggers



ATTACKING CHESS AND KING SAFETY

READ THE POSITION

Loose pieces, exposed kings, overloaded defenders, and opening lines are invitations to search concretely.

PRIMARY PLAN

LOOSE: Did a piece lose a defender?; LINES: Did a file, rank, or diagonal open?; KING: Did shelter or checking access change?; OVERLOAD: Is one piece performing two jobs?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Calculate when I feel danger' with 'Use concrete instability signals.'; Replace 'Tactics happen randomly' with 'Look for the structural trigger first.'; Replace 'Spend equal time each move' with 'Invest time when geometry changes.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Bxc6 dxc6 5. O-O f6 6. d4 exd4 7. Nxd4

MEMORY RULE

Deep calculation should be triggered by evidence, not anxiety.

15. Decision Framework

Recognize Tactical Triggers

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	NOTICE: Ask what the last move changed.; SCAN: Check loose pieces and king access.; TRACE: Follow newly opened lines.; GENERATE: Create forcing candidates.; INVEST: Calculate deeply only if a trigger exists.
PIECE JOB	LOOSE: Undefended and underdefended pieces create targets.; LINES: Newly opened files and diagonals change what can attack.; KING: Reduced shelter raises the value of forcing moves.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	SIGNALS: Instability tells you when to calculate.; CHANGE: The last move often creates the trigger.; GEOMETRY: Lines and overloaded pieces produce tactics.; TIME: Save clock time for positions that deserve it.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

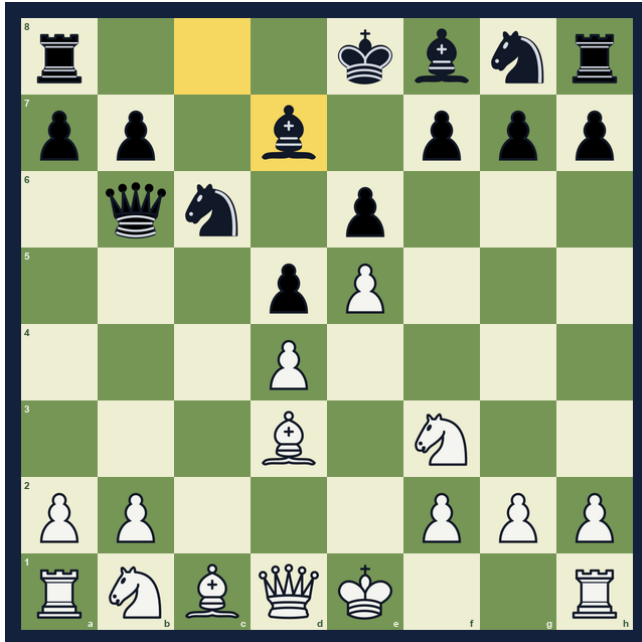
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Deep calculation should be triggered by evidence, not anxiety.

16. Look For The In-Between Move



ATTACKING CHESS AND KING SAFETY

READ THE POSITION

Delay the expected recapture only when the inserted move creates a lasting gain.

PRIMARY PLAN

PAUSE: Do not recapture automatically.; FORCE: Is there a check, capture, or major threat?; RETURN: Can you still complete the exchange later?; SAFETY: What forcing reply does the opponent have?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'I must recapture' with 'Search for one forcing interruption.'; Replace 'Any check is useful' with 'Confirm the move creates lasting value.'; Replace 'I can recapture later' with 'Verify the original piece cannot escape.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 c5 4. c3 Nc6 5. Nf3 Qb6 6. Bd3 cxd4 7. cxd4 Bd7

MEMORY RULE

Before every automatic recapture, give yourself one chance to interrupt.

16. Decision Framework

Look For The In-Between Move

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	PAUSE: Freeze before the expected recapture.; SEARCH: List forcing alternatives.; TEST: Use the opponent's strongest reply.; RETURN: Check that the original capture remains.; COMPARE: Choose the superior move order.
PIECE JOB	ASSUMPTION: Recapture feels mandatory even when it is not.; FORCING: A check or major threat may demand an immediate response.; RETURN: The original recapture must still be available afterward.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	AUTOMATIC: Expected recaptures create blind spots.; FORCE: Only serious interruptions deserve attention.; RETURN: Preserve the original tactical gain.; ORDER: Same moves in a different order can change everything.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Before every automatic recapture, give yourself one chance to interrupt.

17. When To Calculate Deeply



ATTACKING CHESS AND KING SAFETY

READ THE POSITION

Calculate deeply when the move is forcing, irreversible, or changes the evaluation sharply.

PRIMARY PLAN

IRREVERSIBLE: Will the move permanently change structure or material?; UNSTABLE: Are forcing moves dominating?; CHOICES: Do candidates lead to different positions?; CLOCK: Can the decision justify the time cost?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Calculate every candidate' with 'Screen moves before spending time.'; Replace 'Think longest when confused' with 'Look for critical features first.'; Replace 'Save all my time' with 'Invest it at irreversible crossroads.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e5 6. Ndb5 d6 7. Bg5 a6 8. Na3 b5 9. Nd5 Be7

MEMORY RULE

Use your clock on decisions that will shape the rest of the game.

17. Decision Framework

When To Calculate Deeply

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	SCREEN: Check for tactical or structural instability.; SHORTLIST: Keep two or three serious moves.; BUDGET: Choose a reasonable time limit.; CALCULATE: Follow the most critical response.; DECIDE: Stop when one line is clearly preferable.
PIECE JOB	IRREVERSIBLE: Pawn moves, sacrifices, and exchanges cannot be undone.; UNSTABLE: Exposed kings and loose pieces make evaluation volatile.; CHOICE: Critical positions offer several plausible but different paths.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	CRITICAL: Some moves deserve far more time than others.; IRREVERSIBLE: Permanent changes require care.; SCREEN: Do not calculate bad candidates deeply.; STOP: A clear preference is enough to decide.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

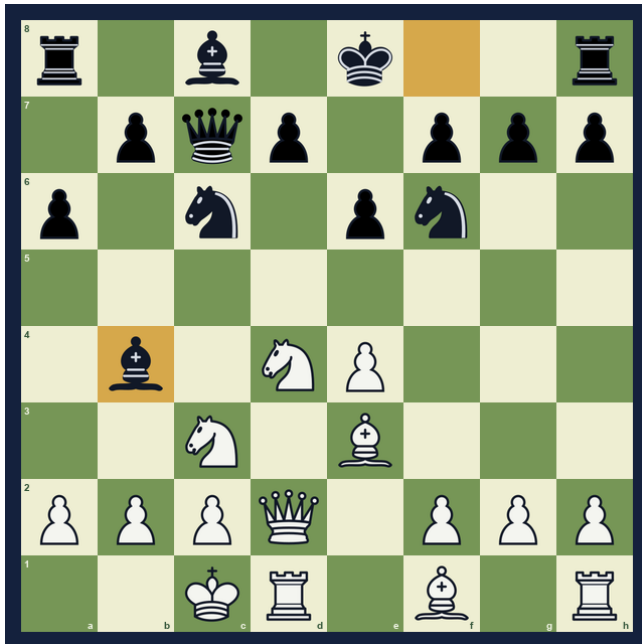
ACTIVE RECALL

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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Use your clock on decisions that will shape the rest of the game.

18. Use Your Clock Like A Budget



ATTACKING CHESS AND KING SAFETY

READ THE POSITION

Use fast routines for familiar positions and deliberate budgets for irreversible choices.

PRIMARY PLAN

BASELINE: What is your normal move budget?; **INVEST:** Is this position truly critical?; **RESERVE:** How much time must remain later?; **COMMIT:** When the budget ends, choose safely.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'More time finds truth' with 'Stop when one move is clearly adequate.'; Replace 'Think deeply in every position' with 'Use routines for ordinary decisions.'; Replace 'I will play fast later' with 'Protect a reserve before trouble begins.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 e6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nc6 5. Nc3 Qc7 6. Be3 a6 7. Qd2 Nf6 8. O-O-O Bb4

MEMORY RULE

Do not try to spend the same care on decisions of different importance.

18. Decision Framework

Use Your Clock Like A Budget

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	GLANCE: Check clock and game phase.; CLASSIFY: Ordinary or critical position?; BUDGET: Set a mental stopping point.; DECIDE: Use the best evidence available.; RESET: Begin the next move fresh.
PIECE JOB	BASELINE: Ordinary moves need a modest default time.; INVESTMENT: Critical positions deserve a deliberate larger spend.; RESERVE: Keep enough time to make safe decisions near the end.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	RESOURCE: Time is part of the position.; UNEQUAL: Critical moves deserve unequal spending.; RESERVE: Late safety requires saved time.; ENOUGH: A sound move on time beats perfection too late.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

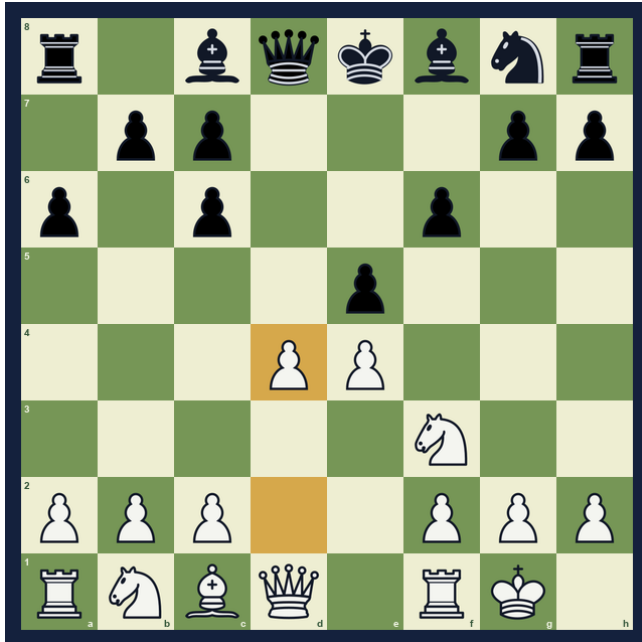
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3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Do not try to spend the same care on decisions of different importance.

19. Defend A Worse Position



ATTACKING CHESS AND KING SAFETY

READ THE POSITION

Reduce the opponent's easiest plan while preserving one source of counterplay.

PRIMARY PLAN

PLAN: What is their easiest winning plan?; TRADE: Which exchange disrupts it most?; COUNTERPLAY: What active resource can you preserve?; FORTRESS: Can you build a stable defensive setup?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'I should wait' with 'Force the opponent to solve a new problem.'; Replace 'Trade anything' with 'Trade the piece that enables their plan.'; Replace 'Create random threats' with 'Preserve credible, sustainable counterplay.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Bxc6 dxc6 5. O-O f6 6. d4

MEMORY RULE

Defend the position by making the opponent prove every part of the win.

19. Decision Framework

Defend A Worse Position

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	ACCEPT: Evaluate the position without panic.; PREDICT: Name their simplest plan.; DISRUPT: Trade, blockade, or change structure.; ACTIVATE: Create one serious source of play.; RESIST: Make every step require accuracy.
PIECE JOB	RESISTANCE: Identify the plan they would choose with unlimited time.; TRADE: Exchange the piece that makes that plan simple.; COUNTERPLAY: Keep one credible threat or pawn break alive.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	NOT LOST: A disadvantage is an evaluation, not a result.; DIFFICULTY: Your job is to complicate conversion.; TARGETED TRADE: Remove the key winning piece.; ACTIVE: Keep one resource the opponent must respect.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

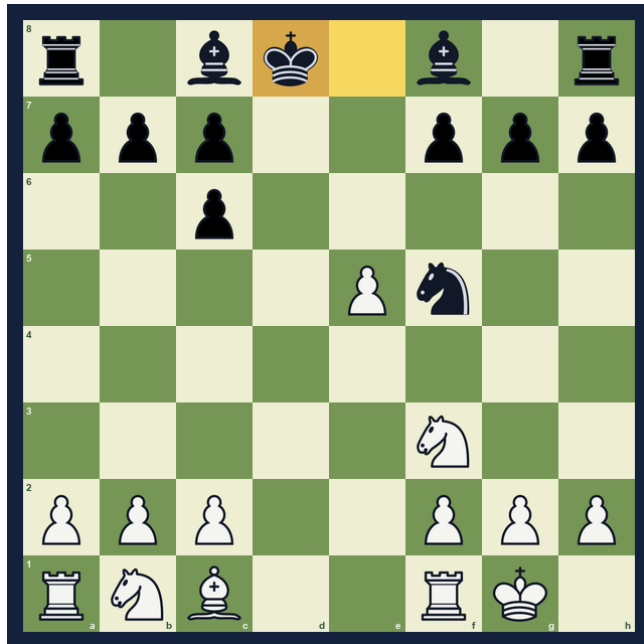
ACTIVE RECALL

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2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Defend the position by making the opponent prove every part of the win.

20. Recover From A Bad Opening



ATTACKING CHESS AND KING SAFETY

READ THE POSITION

Finish development, protect the king, and challenge the opponent's most useful piece or space advantage.

PRIMARY PLAN

SAFETY: What immediate danger must be removed?;
DEVELOP: Which undeveloped piece can join?; TRADE:
Which enemy piece dominates the position?; BREAK: What
pawn move could eventually free you?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'I must regain equality' with 'Aim for a stable
playable position.'; Replace 'Attack to create chances' with
'Complete development before counterplay.'; Replace
'Avoid all exchanges' with 'Trade the piece that sustains
their pressure.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Nf6 4. O-O Nxe4 5. d4 Nd6 6. Bxc6 dxc6 7. dxe5 Nf5 8. Qxd8+ Kxd8

MEMORY RULE

A bad opening becomes survivable when you stop trying to erase it in one move.

20. Decision Framework

Recover From A Bad Opening

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	ACCEPT: Stop fighting the evaluation emotionally.; SECURE: Protect king and loose pieces.; DEVELOP: Bring every piece into the game.; REDUCE: Exchange the strongest enemy piece.; FREE: Prepare the structural break that creates room.
PIECE JOB	SAFETY: Stop immediate tactics and secure the king.; DEVELOPMENT: Bring unused pieces into defensive and active roles.; TRADE: Exchange the piece that makes the opponent's advantage easy.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	STABLE: Playable is the first recovery target.; ONE ERROR: Do not turn an opening mistake into several.; DEVELOP: Unused pieces cannot solve problems.; FREEING BREAK: Know the move that can restore space.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A bad opening becomes survivable when you stop trying to erase it in one move.

Course Completion Test

Choose ten chapters at random. Rebuild each reference position, name both sides' plans, identify the critical break, and state the trade filter without reopening the chapter.

Score one point for the structure, one for your plan, one for counterplay, one for the break, and one for the memory rule. Forty out of fifty means the knowledge is usable; below forty means retrieval practice should continue.

FINAL PRINCIPLE

A course is complete when its ideas appear in your decisions, not when its pages have been read.